



Red-billed quelea

Quelea quelea

Known as Africa's "feathered locust," the red-billed quelea is perhaps the world's most abundant bird. It is nomadic, descending on areas covered with tall seeding grasses or, if they cannot be found, cultivated cereal crops. Although individual birds only eat about $\frac{5}{8}$ oz (18 g) of seed a day, a flock of 2 million birds can consume around 40 tons (36 metric tons). In South Africa alone, more than 180 million queleas are killed each year in pest control operations.

Flocks of red-billed queleas, millions strong, look like billowing clouds of smoke. The birds at the rear constantly leapfrog forward, to take a turn at the front, as the feeding flock forges ahead. Breeding birds weave a ball-shaped nest out of grass when the seasonal rains arrive.

- ↔ 5 in (12 cm)
- ⚖ $\frac{1}{2}$ –1 oz (15–30 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Seeds, insects
- 🏠  Sub-Saharan Africa

▷ SEED CRACKER

The quelea's thick beak is ideal for cracking and peeling seeds held by the tongue. Its red color is simply to impress a potential mate.

thick red beak of
breeding male

